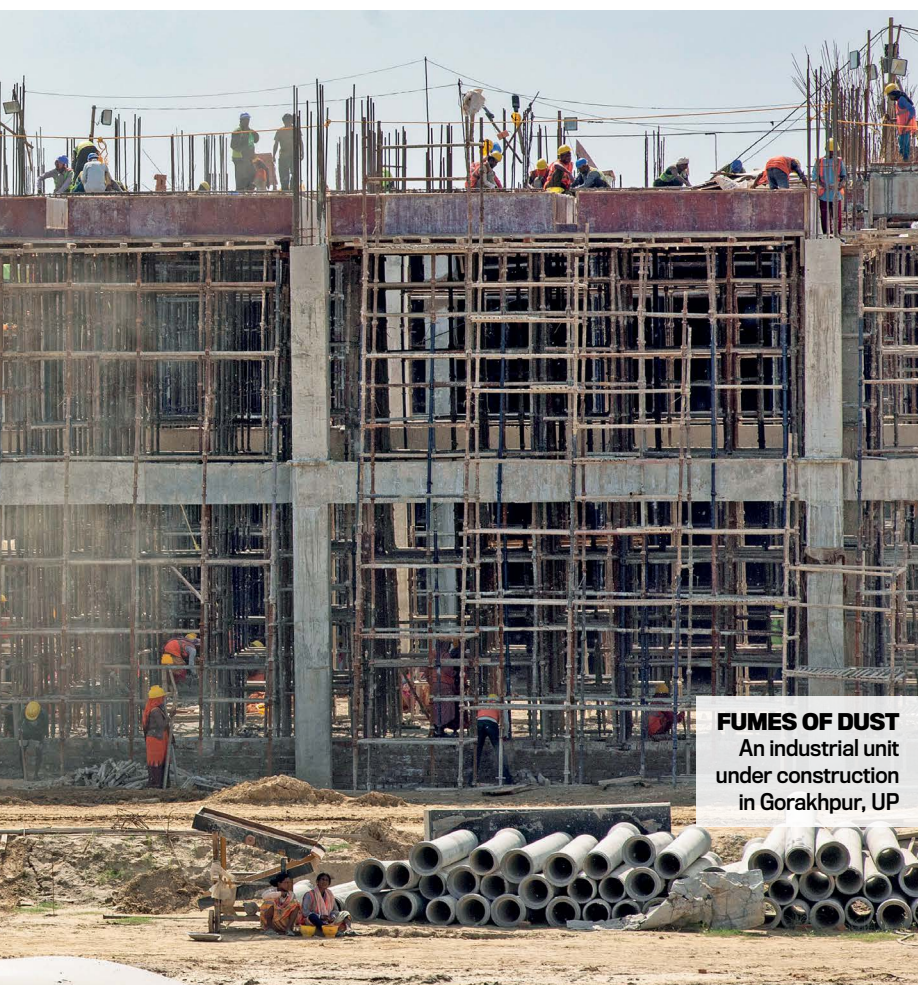
Mumbai joined Delhi this year in the dubious club of cities with dangerous air pollution levels, and took the cue from the national capital to shut down some construction activity and issue guidelines to fortify construction sites. Despite the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) banning garbage burning and warning crackdowns against the 6,000-odd construction projects in the city if they failed to follow the norms, the city's AQI plummeted to 245, or 'severe' category, on November 13, the day after Diwali, celebrating which is deemed incomplete without bursting a few thousand crackers. Environmentalist D. Stalin, director of the NGO Vanashakti, however, attributes Mumbai's air pollution to dust and particulate matter on account of "uncontrolled construction activity". "(Constructions at) government projects are more guilty than private projects," he charges. Excavated dirt at construction sites is left open, the fugitive dust becoming the main pollutant. That it is also transferred and disposed of in open and uncovered trucks does not help matters either.

SOLUTIONS

- **Compliance must be ensured with the Centre's Construction and Demolition Waste Management Rules of 2016. Mumbai's municipal body has warned action against 6,000 projects if they flout existing rules**
- **Wash roads every night, cover material around construction sites with wet green garden cloth**
- **Combine advanced tech with environmental awareness to combat pollution due to construction**
- **Have CAQM-like authority, which can issue graded response plan**

It's a phenomenon common to most Indian metros in the throes of a construction boom. The ongoing infra frenzy in the NCR, for instance, will increase pollution from construction activity by 69-82 per cent by 2030, per a comprehensive air pollution source apportionment study by TERI. Road dust and construction activities, the study reveals, make up around 25 per cent of PM10 and 17 per cent of the much smaller—and hence more dangerous—PM2.5 in Delhi's winter air. "Every stage of construction is a source of toxic dust," says Anumita Roy Chowdhury, executive director, CSE. "There is dust from masonry work, tunnelling, road milling, cement and concrete mixing. There is mining dust from cutting and drilling through sandstone and granite. So, construction has been a problem sector as it adds to particulate matter pollution."

And tackling construction and demolition waste has been a major headache for policymakers. Prashant Gargava, former member-secretary of CPCB, agrees. "It's a sizeable problem," he says. "As a relatively new front in air pollution, compliance may be less than, say, in curbing industrial pollution." The Centre had in 2016 prescribed Construction and Demolition Waste Management Rules, laying down dos and don'ts for developers. These included measures such as covering of construction sites, sprinkling water to suppress dust in the air and covered transportation of construction material, among other things. It also had detailed guidelines on setting up recycling plants for waste. The Swachh Bharat Mission has also done its bit.



FUMES OF DUST An industrial unit under construction in Gorakhpur, UP